The Sense of School Community Scales (Primary and Secondary)

Description and purpose

These scales provide measures of pupils' sense of school community. Appropriate for both primary-school children (aged 8–11 years) and secondary-school children (aged 11–16 years), the scales can be used by schools to address questions such as:

- How are we doing in fostering a sense of community in our pupils?
- Are some groups of pupils at risk of alienation from school?
- Has our recent personalised learning initiatives increased pupils' sense of school community and reduced the gap between the majority and particular vulnerable groups?

Groups of pupils whose sense of school community may require particular consideration and nurturing may include those from economically disadvantaged families, those from minority-ethnic groups or travelling communities, those with special needs and those in public care.

Such questions are especially relevant now. Students' perceptions of their school environment have been identified as important potential targets for school improvement initiatives that aim to raise achievement, reduce discipline problems and improve school safety. This fits with the focus on personalising learning in schools (DfES 2004) and the introduction of the Tellus survey of young people's views (Ofsted 2007). The relevance of school environment to mental health is increasingly recognised and recent preventive initiatives have been focused on changing the social context of schools to better meet pupils' psychological needs. In the UK currently the *Sense of School Community Scales* are being used in the evaluation of a major initiative designed to promote the wellbeing of children and young people: the Secondary Social and Emotional Aspects of Learning (SEAL) programme (DfES 2005).

The *Sense of School Community Scales* are underpinned by the definition of relational communities developed by McMillan and Chavis (1986) which is outlined in the Introduction to this booklet. The scales assess two main elements thought to facilitate pupils' feelings of being valued and competent within school:

- warm and supportive interpersonal relationships;
- opportunities to participate in group norm-setting and decision making..

The *Sense of School Community Scale – Primary* was first used with children aged 8–11 years in the Child Development Project in the United States of America (Battistich et al. 1995). A version for eleven- to sixteen-year-olds was developed subsequently (Battistich et al. 2004).

The *Sense of School Community Scale – Primary* consists of 38 items organised into three subscales:

(a) *Classroom supportiveness* contains 14 items designed to assess the extent to which pupils feel their classmates to be supportive and helpful.

(b) *School supportiveness* contains 14 items designed to assess the extent to which pupils feel their school as a whole is supportive, welcoming and safe.

(c) *Classroom autonomy* contains 10 items designed to assess the extent to which pupils feel they have opportunities to participate in classroom planning and decision making.

The *Sense of School Community Scale – Secondary* consists of 18 items organised into two subscales:

(a) *School supportiveness* contains nine-items.

(b) *Pupil autonomy and influence* contains nine-items.

Pupils respond to each item using a five-point Likert-type scale (1 = 'Disagree a lot'; 5 = 'Agree a lot'). The original term 'student' has been replaced by 'pupil' in the items as this usage is more common in the United Kingdom, particularly in primary schools. The primary version of the questionnaire is orientated towards the classroom, recognising the greater salience of the class group as an influence on pupils' sense of community in primary schools. However, depending on school organisation, this may also be relevant in the early years of secondary school. Hence, rather than selecting the scale to use strictly on stage of education, it will usually be more appropriate to consider the purpose for which information is being collected and select the scale best suited to that purpose. In this respect the classroom autonomy subscale (primary) may be better suited to assessing personalisation of learning, while the pupil autonomy and influence subscale (secondary) samples pupil participation in decision making about broader aspects of school life.

Administration

The scales can be administered to whole class groups. It is good practice to inform pupils at the start of the session about the purpose of the survey and to emphasise that their honest opinion is sought, giving appropriate assurances.

In primary schools, it is recommended that each item is read aloud while pupils follow along on their questionnaire sheet. The response categories can also be read for the first few questions to help ensure that pupils understand what to do. Where possible it is advisable to have a second adult present who circulates among the pupils, answering questions and providing additional help to any who needed it. Individual or small group administration can be used as desired. Where necessary, language support staff may be involved in the administration, to provide support either in English or in a pupil's preferred language.

Scoring

1. A score for each item is entered onto the Scoring Sheet. Items without an 'R' in the first column are scored with the number selected by the pupil. Items which have an 'R' in the first column are scored in the reverse manner (1 for 'Agree a lot', 2 for 'Agree a little', etc.). Omitted or otherwise invalid responses (e.g. where two ratings have been given to the same item) are scored 0. Should a pupil produce more than one invalid response on any subscale their data should be regarded as questionable and use of small group or individual administration considered.

2. To obtain subscale scores, the item scores for each subscale are averaged – summed and divided by the number of items answered in that scale. Subscale totals can then be recorded in the spaces provided on each score sheet.

3. Full-scale scores for the individual pupils' sense of school community are obtained by averaging the subscale scores

4. Multi-level data can be obtained by further averaging – for example, to obtain a sense of school community score for students in different classes or belonging to different ethnic groups. Using the second Scoring Sheets, the names of each class/group completing the measure can be entered, along with the total number of students. A class/group profile is then generated by entering the percentages of students falling into each average score band (very high, high, average, low, very low).

Interpretation

The *Sense of School Community Scales* may be interpreted in two main ways:

- In addressing questions about how well the school is performing overall in promoting a sense of community among its pupils.
- In checking for differences between different groups of pupils.

Overall performance – at present there is no national data in the UK on these scales, although this will change when the results of the Secondary SEAL

evaluation is published. In the interim the results from a US study of 24 primary schools (Battistich et al. 1995) are presented to provide a basis for cautious comparison. The highest school average score in this study was 3.29, while the lowest was 2.56. The average score across all 24 schools of 2.95, almost exactly at the scale midpoint, and standard deviation of 0.17 indicates that for this comparison sample scores above 3.12 can be considered above average and those below 2.78, below average.

Secondary schools should note that sense of school community tends to decrease with age and school averages have been found to be more variable across secondary schools. Battistich et al. (2004) reported an overall average of 2.83 in a sample of secondary schools, where scores above 3.41 might be considered above average and scores below 2.25 below average.

Schools may wish to use the Scoring Sheets to map the scores of different classes/groups.

The study of 24 US primary schools also looked at associations between sense of school community and a number of other contextual factors. Results indicated that as the level of poverty in a school increased the average sense of community became weaker. Socio-economic disadvantage is therefore an important factor to bear in mind in interpreting a school's overall score.

Within-school group differences – while simple comparison of the average scores obtained by particular groups of pupils will provide some information, use of statistical tests will provide a better indication of the reliance that can be placed on the results obtained and schools may want to consult their educational psychology service for assistance with this.

Socio-economic disadvantage has been identified as an important factor in interpreting a school's overall score and further research showed that high scores on sense of school community can help to ameliorate the negative effects of poverty on student outcome measures such as educational expectations (Battistich et al. 1997). Schools would be well advised to compare the scores of pupils eligible for free school meals with those from more affluent backgrounds and identify ways of addressing any gap in sense of school community.

While each school will have different groups in which it is interested, among the other within-school group comparisons which may be routine worth considering are:

Gender – females generally score higher than males.

Ethnicity – for example, in their study of 24 US primary schools Battistich et al. (1995) found that Asian (3.13) and Hispanic students (3.05) scored higher than White (2.95) and African-American students (2.84).

Technical details

Battistich et al. (2000) report high internal consistency for the overall score on the primary scale (a = .91) and for the subscales: classroom supportiveness (α = .85), school supportiveness (α = .86) and classroom autonomy (α = .81). Roberts et al. (1995) reported that the scale was equally reliable for boys and girls and for students of different ethnic backgrounds. Battistich et al. (2004) report acceptable internal consistency (α = .81) also for the secondary scale.

In order to provide a measure of the convergent validity of the *Sense of School Community Scale – Primary*, Battistich et al. (1995) developed a parallel scale for teachers (α = .81). The correlation between this measure and the *Sense of School Community Scale* completed by the pupils (each aggregated to the school level) was .64 ($p < .001$), indicating good convergent validity between pupil and teacher perceptions of pupils' sense of school community.

Battistich et al. (1997) summarised a range of broader validity findings showing that sense of school community is significantly related to a range of desirable outcomes for pupils, such as learning motivation, sense of efficacy, altruistic behaviour and conflict resolution skills. Of particular relevance to children's mental health and wellbeing are findings that schools with higher scores on sense of community have lower average pupil self-reported drug use and delinquency (Battistich and Hom 1997).

Comparison with similar measures

A number of other measures have been designed to assess aspects of the concept of community developed by McMillan and Chavis (1986). Battistich et al. (1995) differentiate such measures on two dimensions:

(a) *Individual versus group focus?* Some measures focus on individual aspects. For example, Goodenow's (1993) *Psychological Sense of School Membership Scale* (which is also contained in this booklet of measures) assesses the individual's feeling of belonging and being welcome, and the measure developed by Wehlage et al. (1990) assesses the individual's bonding to peers, teachers and school. By contrast Bryk and Driscoll (1988), like Battistich et al. (1995), consider community to be a group-level (classroom or school) construct that has an individual-level aspect, namely the individual's feeling of membership in the community.

(b) *Whose perception is assessed?* Bryk and Driscoll (1988) focus on operationalising the broader construct of school as community, including multiple indicators of shared values and a common agenda of activities; however, their measure does not represent caring and supportive social relations among members or members' influence on group activities or decisions. Their measure also collects information predominately from teachers rather than pupils, so differentiating it from those developed by Goodenow (1993) and Battistich et al. (1995) which focus on pupil perceptions.

More recently Vieno et al. (2007) have carried out a number of studies of sense of school community as a mediator of social support on psychosocial adjustment. They used a six-item measure of school sense of community designed to reflect three of the four dimensions in the McMillan and Chavis (1986) framework: membership, shared emotional connection and fulfilment of needs. They do not include the fourth dimension, group influence, which has an important role in the Battistich et al. (1995, 2004) measures.

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